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Volume XXXV Number 13; For the week
March 23-29, 2010, released on March 22

• Editorial Office Living Media India Ltd. F-14/15, Connaught Place New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23315801-4; Fax: 23316180; Cable: Livmedia, New Delhi
• Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (UP)-201301; Phone: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines); (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and Faridabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m.-6 p.m.); Fax: (0120) 4078080; e-mail: svcs@indiatoday.com; Mumbai: 022-24444423-6; Fax: 24444358 • Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Component House, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place, New Delhi • Regd. Office: K-9 Connaught Circus, New Delhi 110001 • Impact Office: Trade Centre, 2nd Floor, Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 • Hamilton House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23352233; Fax: 23327330 • 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai, 2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004; Phone: 28478526-41; Telex: 041-6177 Into In; Fax: 28472178; Cable: Livmedia Chennai • 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phone: 22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; Cable: Livmedia, Bangalore • 52, Jawahar Nidra Road, 4th Floor, Kallada-700071; Phone: 23825398; Fax: 22827254; Cable: Livmedia, Kolkata • 6-3-8857/8, Somajiguda, Hyderabad-500082; Phone: 23401657, 23400479, 23410100, 23402481, 23410982, 23411498; Fax: 23403464 • 39/1045, Karakast Road, Kochi 682016; Phone: 2377057, 2377058; Fax: 2377059 • 2/C, 'Suryarath Bldg', 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchwati, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006; Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293 • Copyright Living Media India Ltd. All rights reserved throughout the world. Reproduction in any manner is prohibited. Printed and published by Ashish Bagga on behalf of Living Media India Ltd. Printed at Thomson Press India Ltd., 16-35 Millennium, Delhi Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007. (Rajya) A-9, Industrial Complex, Marudai Nagar, District Kancheepuram-603209, (Tamil Nadu); and at Post No. 5-5A, TTC Industrial Area, Thane, Belapur Road, Airoli, Navi Mumbai-400708. (Maharashtra). Published at K-9, Connaught Circus, New Delhi-110001.
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From the editor-in-chief

When I say the India Today Conclave marks two very special days in my calendar, that's not only because the Conclave is organised by our magazine. For those two days, all of us become learners and participants in a world of ideas. This year, scholars, politicians, bureaucrats, thinkers and actors were drawn together around the Conclave's theme, 'New Decade: Great Expectations'. These were highly-skilled specialists possessing an astonishing breadth of knowledge communicated in an insightful and interactive manner.

The Conclave was a meeting of many powerful minds. What emerged was the thought that the next decade was a tipping point for both India and the rest of the world. It is the time we must decisively tackle terrorism and the after-effects of two different meltdowns: the global economy and the environment. The last decade was book-ended by the ghastly acts of 9/11 which changed the world and a crippling global recession. India got a double whammy with 26/11. All this reminded us that security of all kinds—of life and our financial well-being—was deeply connected in an interdependent world. It told us once again that no nation could think of itself as an island. India straddles two worlds. In one it is a soft target for terror and in the other, a booming economy that has attracted a western world now desperately looking for new big markets.

Home Minister P. Chidambaram opened the Conclave in a session that was informative, entertaining and hit the headlines. Another 26/11-type incident, he said, would lead to 'swift and decisive action'. Then he took on the Pakistani high commissioner, saying all India needed as proof that non-state actors were involved in jihadi terror was a verification of the voices of the 26/11 handlers.

Speaking for an India within its borders, Kapil Sibal, minister for human resource development, painted a lucid, inspirational grand vision of our entire education system which left the audience awestruck. CISCO Chairman John Chambers said technology could drive change in critical sectors, with a future dependent, not on "command and control" but "collaboration and teamwork". He offered the audacious goal of a virtual learning revolution taking education to every Indian for a dollar a month.

Author Salman Rushdie in a most well-crafted, eloquent speech spoke about the role of art in society and warned India against giving itself up to extremism and sectarian thinking. Harvard economics guru David Bloom's speech about the future of India's population pulled in Rahul Gandhi, widely regarded as a politician with whom great expectations seem to rest. Bloom talked about India's population dividend turning into a disaster if the expectations of its vast and burgeoning youth were not met.

This year we chose two people from the arts to speak on the future of cinema. This is a world in which the imagined can often turn into the real a few decades down the line. One was James Cameron, responsible for the biggest box office hit in the world, and the other, Aamir Khan, for the biggest hit in Bollywood.

As part of our cover story this week, we have decided to give you the best excerpts of an absorbing two days which contained a treasure chest of ideas and innovations. It is clear that technological advances in the communications business will continue to transform our lives in a way we cannot imagine. How well we do in the next decade will depend a lot on how nations work on the most critical issues facing us—global terrorism, international financial regulation and the endangered environment.

(Aroon Purie)



OUR MARCH 2009
CONCLAVE COVER